

CHAMPIONS: The victory ride in Bangalore

COLTS READY FOR A BIG LEAP

For India's junior champions it will be a long and arduous road into the game's big league

■ By Hemant Kenkre in Kuala Lumpur

God gave you two hours to finish the game," said HRH Tunku Imran, president of the Malaysian Cricket Association, "and you did it." As the rain came down, Tunku and ICC president Ray Mali, looked over at a flushed, excited group of Indian teenagers holding on to the ICC Under-19 World Cup just having beaten South Africa in a thrilling final at the Kinrara Oval.

The South African run chase of a meagre total had been interrupted by rain but India were not to be denied. A small window of dry weather was their only opportunity and India used the time available to break through the South African batting line-up.

The Kinrara Oval in Puchong, a short drive from the Kuala Lumpur city centre, is flanked by a mosque, a highway and a huge superstore. The highway and the store was an ideal backdrop for cricketers on the fast

track to fame in a sport that had just witnessed its first auction. The regular call to prayer from the mosque acted as a reminder of higher pursuits and the perfect antidote for frayed nerves.

India had easily beaten South Africa in a group game but just before the final, South African coach Ray Jennings sent out a message that his team were no pushovers. Jennings, controversial, colourful former coach of the senior South Africans said, "The expectations on India (to win) are high back home. I'm going to come from the bottom and see if I can scare not only the team but India as a country." Sadly for his team, Jennings never spoke about the actual business of winning.

The Indians kept their eye on the main business—winning—and post-victory, danced around like pre-

teens given a gobble-all-you-can entry into a chocolate factory. The Indian skipper Virat Kohli was pumping his fist and letting go multi-lingual expletives in a show of rather uncalled-for aggression. Perhaps the lightning call from the BCCI giving each member of the team Rs 15 lakh, a chartered flight back home and an open-top bus reception had served as extra fuel.

Apart from Tanmay Srivastava being reprimanded by the ICC for pointing a Kiwi batsman back to the pavilion during the semi-final, the Indians took back more than a few good moments.

The new ball bowlers Pradip Sangwan and Ajitesh Argal stuck to



"This group of BOYS is really serious about their CRICKET, and they hate losing, even a practice match."

DAV WHATMORE, COACH, INDIAN U-19 TEAM